

Chapter 157-1

The cold winter sun penetrated through the glass, refracting into the room, and happened to illuminate the five words "Divorce Agreement."

Those words gradually blurred.

Mist filled her vision, and her heart seemed to stop beating in that instant.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu finally moved her lips, but no sound came out.

She was trying to find her voice, but to no avail.

The good mood that had rarely come from a full night's sleep instantly vanished into thin air.

In the quiet room, Xu Qingzhu sat in the chair, reading the words on the sticky note over and over again, until the mist in her eyes became so thick she couldn't see anything.

She slowly closed her eyes, and tears fell onto the A4 paper.

This was a rare sunny winter day in Haizhou City.

Xu Qingzhu sat woodenly in the room for an entire day, her phone on Do Not Disturb mode, without eating anything.

Until nightfall descended and the entire city sank into darkness, the streetlights flickered on in an instant.

Like a beam of light shining into the darkness.

Yet, Xu Qingzhu's world had completely fallen into darkness.

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In the morning, Liang Shi drove around half of Haizhou City like a wandering ghost before dawn.

She saw the morning sun falling on the Yujiang Bridge and witnessed the city's dawn.

Everything seemed full of life and vitality, but she had no intention of appreciating it.

In the end, with nowhere to go, she bought some alcohol and went to find Zhao Xuning.

At that time, Zhao Xuning was still sound asleep. She opened the door impatiently with her hair sticking up in all directions, her voice hoarse as she said through gritted teeth: "You'd better have something important."

"I'm getting divorced." Liang Shi said in a low voice, standing at the door.

Zhao Xuning was stunned, and her sleepiness and morning grumpiness vanished without a trace in an instant.

"What do you mean?" Zhao Xuning closed the door behind her.

Liang Shi placed the alcohol she'd bought on the coffee table and shrugged with a bitter smile: "Exactly what it sounds like."

"Did you get the certificate done?"¹ Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi: "...Not yet."

"Then how is that a divorce?" Zhao Xuning smoothed her hair, rummaged through a drawer for a hair tie, and casually tied her hair up. "Besides, aren't you and Xu Qingzhu in the honeymoon phase? How could you have fought?"

As soon as she finished speaking, Liang Shi said in a low voice: "I signed the divorce agreement."

Zhao Xuning's hand that was tying her hair paused, then she unhurriedly put on her glasses, and her vision finally became clearer.

She didn't pay attention to Liang Shi and went straight to the bathroom to wash her face. When she came out, Liang Shi was drinking in sullen silence.

Zhao Xuning walked over and opened a can for herself as well. "So?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She hadn't expected Zhao Xuning to accept it so well.

She'd thought she would at least ask about the reason or something.

But this was also fine. Liang Shi came to find Zhao Xuning precisely because she always had a sense of propriety and boundaries. When you treated her as a close friend, you might get hurt by her somewhat cold attitude.

But when encountering situations like this, you'd feel it was so good to have a friend like Zhao Xuning.

She would never ask too many questions.

"I have nowhere to stay." Liang Shi said. "Let me crash here for a few days."

Hearing this, Zhao Xuning took out her phone and called her—it was powered off.

"Not going to work?" Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "Just wrapped up a production. I'll see if there's any work these few days."

"Your phone isn't even on—where would work come from?" Zhao Xuning took a sip of alcohol, felt a bitter taste in her mouth, got up and opened the refrigerator, then focused on cutting vegetables and cooking.

She had no intention of insisting that Liang Shi say anything.

And Liang Shi was content to amuse herself, chatting casually with her for a bit before drinking in silence.

The dishes Zhao Xuning made to go with the drinks tasted decent. Liang Shi ate some, then drank another can of beer, and her head ached a bit.

"I need to go home for a bit." Zhao Xuning said. "Your activity space is limited to the common areas and that bedroom. My bedroom—don't even touch the door."

"Got it, Dr. Zhao." Liang Shi nodded and got up to walk toward the room Zhao Xuning had indicated.

It was similar to the previous bedroom, both having a very minimalist² decorating style.

Simple and clear, but with all the necessary furniture.

Liang Shi had been awake almost the entire night and had been drinking all last night, so now her head was splitting.

She threw her already powered-off phone into the drawer, lay on the bed, and buried herself in sleep.

She didn't even notice when Zhao Xuning left.

Zhao Xuning sat in the living room and cleaned up the two empty bottles, and the living room returned to its untouched appearance.

She sat on the sofa and sent a message to Xu Qingzhu: What are you doing?

The other party didn't reply.

A few seconds later, Zhao Xuning withdrew the message.

She couldn't be bothered to deal with these matters.

Zhao Xuning's home was decorated like a hotel, with everything neatly categorized and placed by this obsessive-compulsive person. She hired cleaning services three times a week.

Aside from the bedroom, study, bathroom, and kitchen, she rarely went anywhere else.

And the master bedroom had its own bathroom.

So she could take Liang Shi in for a few days.

1. In China, an official divorce requires going to the civil affairs bureau to obtain a divorce certificate, similar to how marriage requires obtaining a marriage certificate. Simply signing a divorce agreement is not legally binding without this official step. ⇐
2. The original Chinese term "性冷淡风" literally translates to "frigid/cold style," which in Chinese interior design terminology refers to a minimalist, neutral-toned aesthetic that emphasizes clean lines and simplicity. This design trend became popular in China in the 2010s, inspired by Scandinavian and Japanese minimalism. ⇐